



Right by your side: As Lakshya stood on the brink of an Olympic medal, Prakash Padukone and Vimal Kumar were courtside, witnessing the potential fulfillment of a dream shared by Lakshya and the entire Indian badminton community. RITU RAJ KONWAR

By the way, Prakash himself took responsibility to up his game by travelling to Denmark and was there for a few years to train and practise with the Danish players, after which he became the world-beater that he was. So when he talks about taking responsibility, he knows what he is saying.

As far back as 2017/18, Prakash, who I unfortunately meet rarely, had told me about this kid, Lakshya Sen. He had taken him under his wing and was his guide and mentor. He would have watched Lakshya's progress step by step. As he came to the cusp of an Olympic medal, Prakash was by the courtside along with the hard-working and indefatigable Vimal Kumar to see the fulfilment of not just Lakshya's dream but also that of the entire community of Indian badminton lovers.

To then see a 20-17 and 7-0 lead being squandered off in the semifinal and then lose the bronze medal match after winning the first game comfortably must have been gut-wrenching indeed. He, Vimal Kumar, the BAI, and the government's TOPS had done everything possible, but when it came to the crunch, Lakshya was, in the famous words of the Indian cricket team captain, "*garden mein ghoomne wala*."

For those who watched both the semifinal and the bronze medal matches, it did appear that Lakshya had lost his trend of thought and concentration in the way he looked at his racquet as he sipped from his water bottle in between points or at the changeovers. I could be completely wrong, but on TV, it looked like a

blank expression, and that's usually a sign that the mind has wandered. Concentration and focus are things that no coach or trainer can ever teach. It can be developed over the years by the athlete by observing other champions and having an inner resolve, but there's no specific programme for it. Yes, mind trainers are around, but they can only do so much and not more. It's got to be within the athlete.

If there was one magnificent example of the mind conquering everything, it could be seen in how P. R. Sreejesh, our super duper hockey goalkeeper, guarded his post. It was best illustrated in the shootout against Great Britain, where he put his life on the line for his country.

He, of course, does it every game, but that was a make-or-break game against Great Britain. His determination, doggedness and never-say-die spirit rubbed off on his teammates as they played remarkable hockey to bring India a bronze medal. It was heartwarming and uplifting — the kind that makes the heart swell with pride.

India may not have won as many medals as was hoped before the Games began. But the medals and even fourth-placed finishes will hopefully start a sporting culture revolution that will bring more medals of all hues in future world competitions.

The facilities and the funds are all there now, from the Federations, the government, and private sponsors. The focus and resolve, though, have to be the athlete's responsibility, as the one and only Prakash Padukone says.